
TEAM A/TEAM B

Use of separate analytic teams that contrast two (or more) strongly held views or competing hypotheses.

WHEN TO USE

A Team A/Team B approach is different from Devil's Advocacy, where the purpose is to challenge a single dominant mind-set. Instead, Team A/Team B recognizes that there may be competing and possibly equally strong mind-sets held on an issue that need to be clarified. Sometimes analysts confuse the two techniques by drafting a Team B exercise that is really a Devil's Advocacy exercise.

If there are at least two competing views within an analytic office or perhaps competing opinions within the policymaking community on a key issue, then Team A/Team B analysis can be the appropriate technique to use. Developing a full-blown Team A/Team B exercise requires a significant commitment of analytic time and resources, so it is worthwhile considering if the analytic issue merits this kind of attention.

A longstanding policy issue, a critical decision that has far-reaching implications, or a dispute within the analytic community that has obstructed effective cross-agency cooperation would be grounds for using Team A/Team B. If those circumstances exist, then analysts will need to review all of the data to develop alternative papers that can capture the essential differences between the two viewpoints.

VALUE ADDED

Managers have found that when there are office tensions among competing factions of analysts, a Team A/Team B approach can help opposing experts see the merit in the other group's perspective. The process of conducting such an exercise can reduce the friction and even narrow the differences. At a minimum, it allows those holding opposing views to feel that their views have been given equal attention.

For the policymaker, this technique helps to surface and explain important analytic differences within the expert community. Often senior officials can learn more by weighing well-argued conflicting views than from reading an assessment that masks substantive differences or drives analysis to the lowest common denominator. By making the key assumptions and information used for each argument more transparent, a policymaker can judge the merits of each case, pose questions back to the analysts, and reach an independent judgment on which argument is the strongest. Moreover, highlighting alternative views puts collectors on notice that they need to be searching for new information that can confirm or disconfirm a range of hypotheses.

If opposing positions are well established, it can be useful to place analysts on teams that will advocate positions they normally do not support; forcing analysts to argue "the other side" can often make them more aware of their own mind-set.